

7/Implications in the United States and Abroad

In American higher education, excellence, merit, and quality are often captured by quantitative measures such as GRE and SAT scores (if you are a student) or number of citations (if you are a researcher). But when it comes to evaluating the proposed work of academics across disciplines, simple measures like these usually will not do. Instead, scholars are brought together to deliberate the merits of these proposals. As historians, political scientists, anthropologists, and literary scholars weigh in with their particular expertise, they also learn from one another, improvise, opine, convince, and attempt to balance competing standards. They strategize, high-ball, and follow scripts shaped by their academic disciplines, but they also contextualize and compromise. They respect alternative perspectives and expect reciprocity. They try to impress other panelists, save face, and help others do the same. They set the agenda, flex their muscles, see if they measure up, and enjoy intellectual barter. They invest themselves in decisions and share excitement with others. They reach “good enough” solutions instead of ideal ones, because they have to

get the job done in the time allotted. They go home usually feeling that they have risen to the occasion, betraying neither “the system” nor themselves. They have stood for principles, but not so rigidly that they could not reach consensus. For them, panels are an opportunity to be influential, and to be appreciated.

Within practical constraints, panelists aim to “produce the sacred” of fair evaluation, while respecting institutional, disciplinary, and other diversities. In particular, disciplinary cultures are tempered by the exigencies of multidisciplinary evaluation. Evaluators aim for consistency in standards across disciplines even as they use standards appropriate to the discipline of the applicant. They both engage in consensual and egalitarian decision making and defer to expertise. In addition, evaluators attempt to balance meritocracy and diversity, seeing these as complementary ideals, not alternatives.

The panelists’ experience reflects many of the system’s tensions, and the doubts these tensions create. Just how biased is academia? Do people get what they deserve? Am I getting what I deserve? Their collective evaluation mobilizes and intertwines emotions, self-interest, and expertise. Moreover, it requires coordinating actions and judgments through a culture of evaluation that has been established long before the panelists set foot in the deliberative chambers.

This story is fundamentally about fairness and the attempt to achieve it. What is presented as expertise may sometimes be merely preference (“taste”), described in depersonalized language. The reciprocal recognition of authority is central to the process, but it may lead to explicit horse-trading, which produces suboptimal results. Despite these potential hazards, however, panelists think the process works, in part because they adopt a pragmatic conception of “truth” (or at least of what constitutes a “fair evaluation”) as something inevitably provisional and defined by the best standards of the community at the time.¹ Indeed, the constraints on the evaluative process—particularly the considerable time that panelists spend pre-

paring for deliberations and their dedication to convincing their peers of the merit of their point of view—go a long way toward creating the conditions for a more meritocratic system. The performative effects of positing a meritocratic system are comparable to those of having “faith in the market”: the belief creates the conditions of its own existence—within limits.²

Some academics have a propensity to assume that quality is intrinsic to the work and that some scholars have a natural talent for finding it. But in fact the “cream” does not rise naturally to the top, nor is it “dug out” in unlikely places: it is produced through expert interaction, with the material provided by applicants. Neither the work nor the people are socially disembedded. Panelists’ definitions of excellence are rooted and arise from their networks of colleagues and ideas. They aim for fairness, but the taken-for-granted aspects of social life—the cognitive structures they use routinely, the multiple networks of which they are a part—may lead them to assume that what appeals to them is simply best.

So evaluation is contextual and relational, and the universe of comparables is constantly shifting. Proposals demand varied standards, because they shine under different lights. In some cases, the significance of the proposed work is determined by the likely generalizability of its findings. In others, how a topic informs our understanding of broader processes is more important. In yet other cases, significance is assessed by the deeper understanding that results from a particular interpretation. In panel deliberations, the ideal of a consistent or universalist mode of evaluation is continually confronted with the reality that different proposals require a plurality of assessment strategies.

This plurality manifests itself starkly when disciplinary evaluative cultures are exposed in the kinds of arguments that individual panelists make for or against proposals, and in how these arguments are received—factors that together influence which proposals will be

funded. In evaluating excellence, formal and informal criteria of evaluation are weighed differently by humanists, social scientists, and historians. Yet across fields, excellence is viewed as a moral as well as a technical accomplishment. It is thought to be a result of determination and hard work, humility, authenticity, and audacity. Other “evanescent qualities” count too, even if, as is the case for elegance and the display of cultural capital, they run counter to the meritocratic ideal that animates the system.

The self-concept of evaluators is central to the process of assessment, especially to the perception that the decision making is fair. Panelists evaluate one another as they evaluate proposals. Their respect for customary rules sustains their identity as experts and as fair and broadminded academics, who as such deserve to serve on funding panels. Yet if their self-concept orients knowledge production and evaluation, panelists downplay its role, often viewing it as an extraneous and corrupting influence.³

For most panelists, interdisciplinarity and diversity are aspects of excellence, not alternatives to it. Because there is a lack of agreement on the standards of evaluation for interdisciplinary genres, panelists readily fall back on the tools they have available—existing disciplinary standards—to determine what interdisciplinary research should be funded. While debates about diversity in higher education have focused mostly on gender and racial and ethnic diversity, the scholars I talked to were most concerned with institutional and disciplinary diversity. They see diversity as a good that can lead to a richer academic life for all and to a broader production of talent for society as a whole.

Like the panelists in my study, many American academics take for granted the legitimacy of the peer review system. Yet estimates of the fairness of the meritocratic process may ebb and flow with one’s own academic successes and level of ambition. Empirical research should establish whether outsiders have the least faith. The peer review process is deeply influenced by who gets asked to serve as a panelist and

what viewpoints and intellectual habitus those individuals bring to the table. Biases are unavoidable. In particular, program officers tend to extend invitations to the most collegial (who may be the least objectionable and most conventional) scholars and those whose careers are already established. Thus peer review is perceived to be biased against daring and innovative research—an explanation I have often consoled myself with when my own research proposals have been denied funding. And it is true that, at the end of the day, we cannot know for sure whether the “cream rises.” But if panelists believe that it does, and make considerable sacrifices to do a good job, they contribute to sustaining a relatively meritocratic system. A system where cynicism prevailed at all levels would most likely generate much greater arbitrariness, and would result in less care being put into the decision-making process and into the preparation of applications.

Exporting the U.S. Evaluation Model Abroad

The peer review system I have described is often associated with American higher education, although it is of course practiced elsewhere. Particularly in Europe, this system has become an explicit point of reference for the teaching reforms of the “Bologna Process” put in place by the member states of the European Union.⁴ Named after a 1999 Bologna Declaration, this process “puts in motion a series of reforms needed to make European Higher Education more compatible and comparable, more competitive and more attractive for Europeans and students and scholars from other continents . . . to match the performance of the best performing systems in the world, notably the United States and Asia.”⁵ Under the impetus of this declaration, the higher education systems of several European countries (including France and Germany) are undergoing major transformations aimed at bringing about greater standardization by 2010. References to peer review figure prominently in these efforts—

along with calls for other forms of rationalization, measurement, rankings, accreditations, standardization, and so on.⁶

These national conversations often have as a background idealized, vague, or ill-informed views concerning the actual practice of peer review in the United States today. Moreover, rarely is there a systematic reflection on the conditions that sustain such a system. For instance, conspicuous collegiality is essential in a vast, largely anonymous system where trust and tight social control through interpersonal contacts cannot be assumed; blind review is facilitated by the large number of universities and the sheer size of the academic community; and the geographic dispersion of universities makes centralized panel deliberation a necessity. These aspects do not apply to most European societies, and European policymakers do not always consider these conditions for the implementation of grant peer review. It is my hope that this book will inform these European conversations. Consideration of the roles played by unions of academics, the state, professional organizations, national funding agencies, and foundations in the evaluation of research and the distributed of resources is important. But so too is consideration of the legacy of different evaluative cultures, including whether meritocracy is considered a grand illusion, an impossibility, or a goal that can be approximated.

Consider the case of France. Today, many French scholars are skeptical of their colleagues' ability to have informed and disinterested opinions regarding the work of their peers.⁷ Pierre Bourdieu's *Homo Academicus*, for example, used survey data to analyze the criteria of evaluation operating in university departments and research institutes.⁸ Bourdieu argued that the criteria privileged in various institutions correspond to the type of endowment that their members are most likely to have. Traditional institutions such as the Sorbonne and the Ecole Normale Supérieure d'Ulm privilege traditional criteria of evaluation, such as mastering the philosophical foundation of a discipline and having a general culture, as opposed to acquiring a

deep understanding of recent developments within substantive subfields. Cynicism toward meritocracy is often taken for granted, as is the view that evaluation is closely and directly tied to interpersonal networks, to localism.⁹ The strong competition for a small number of positions in France may lead French applicants to delegitimize the system, dismissing those who “win” as simply better strategists or as benefiting from better support by their networks—not as more deserving.

In her comparison of university hiring decisions in France, Germany, and the United States, Christine Musselin has argued that Bourdieu exaggerated the extent to which the field position of academic institutions affects the criteria of evaluation used by scholars. She found that institutional location accounts for less than 15 percent of the variance in criteria. She concludes, however, that “personal connections” play a particularly crucial role in hiring for administrative and teaching positions in France. It turns out that the prime concern of hiring commissions is not ensuring fairness but reducing uncertainty concerning the different types of hires.¹⁰

This type of empirical study is exactly what is needed if we are to understand better how peer review is practiced across contexts and how its characteristics are the product of distinct national conditions. In particular we need to understand whether and how fairness is produced differently across systems of higher education. How do the French and American cultures of excellence, and the meanings attributed to the term, influence the evaluative practices of academics in both countries? The cult of success is found across a range of universities in the United States—from the smallest to the largest. What alternative grammars do we find in France?

Toward an Even More Social View of Peer Review

In line with rhetoricians and sociologists of science who address the coproduction of intersubjectivity, I have been concerned with

how scholar-evaluators serving on peer review panels come to agreements through interactions.¹¹ My study examined not only how panelists justify their judgments, but also how the processes and rules of practice set the stage for a sense of legitimacy. This approach is in stark contrast to what remains the dominant approach in the study of peer review, with a focus on the abstract norms of science that are said to govern peer review, particularly norms regarding universalism and disinterestedness.

Panelists do not simply enact the rule of meritocracy (as functionalism would have it); they engage in a genuinely social—that is, interactional—micro-political process of collective decision making. They draw emotional and cognitive boundaries between the work they appreciate and the work they do not, and they do so within relationships of exchange and deliberation. The relationships they form during the negotiation process, based largely on shared “taste,” influence the outcome, as do their preexisting networks, the epistemological and cultural similarities and differences between the fields they hail from, and their own temperaments and idiosyncrasies.

The older as well as the more recent literature on peer review focuses on issues of partiality and fallibility, as well as on risk avoidance, the Matthew effect, bias in favor of research that confirms commonly accepted theory, gender and ideological bias, and other external factors that may influence the possibility that a particular project will be labeled “of quality.”¹² Authors have shown that the characteristics of scientists have very little effect on the evaluation of proposals, due to a lack of consensus among reviewers and self-selection among applicants.¹³ This literature focuses on factors that can be viewed as somewhat exogenous and anomalous, but which may come to disturb the ordinary order of things. I maintain that such influences are fundamental to the peer review process, because evaluation is embedded in social and cognitive networks. Elements

intrinsic to the evaluation process should not be construed as corrupting that process.¹⁴ Trying to remove subjectivity entirely from evaluation is doomed to failure, because the evaluation process is intersubjective. The panelists' sense of the legitimacy of the process is as tied to unwritten customary rules that they themselves produced (and reproduce), as it is to broader norms of universalism and professionalism.

The literature on peer review proposes remedies such as double-blinding (or deleting from proposals bibliographic references that could lead to identification of researchers) in order to overcome known pitfalls. Yet given the contextual nature of evaluation, this strategy would not remove the possibility of bias. Although imperfect safeguards can still have value, it would be more useful to educate panelists about how peer evaluation works. It is particularly important to emphasize the dangers of homophily and how it prevents the identification of a wide range of talents. My hope is that the content of this book and the conversations it generates will make evaluators more aware of the influence of their personal "tastes" and, particularly, more concerned with actively countering their own idiosyncratic judgments.

In addition, at a minimum, peer review processes themselves should be subject to further evaluation, in order to determine, for instance, the most effective size of panels, the order in which panelists should look at elements of proposals, how often panelists should be rotated, and the criteria (formal and informal) by which they should be chosen. We may also need a more systematic approach to training screeners and to advising and supervising program officers. Overall, our collective aim should be to make the review process more transparent, while maintaining the privacy of the deliberations. And we must always acknowledge the inevitable element of randomness, chance, and plain dumb luck.

The panelists I interviewed might be said to be aiming for what

Jürgen Habermas describes as ideal speech conditions.¹⁵ The fact that these evaluators are not part of a closely connected community probably increases their ability to keep their personal interests at bay. In this context, the book contains implications for scholars interested in deliberation and in decision theory.¹⁶ Decision theory, strongly influenced by utility theory, posits that decisions are driven by the information required to assess the utility of various outcomes.¹⁷ My analysis questions the notion of culturally disembodied evaluation and the view that some outcomes would be more rational than others.

My analysis is not, however, based exclusively on the discourse of justification. Nor do I claim to formulate an analysis of fields regarding position and discourse, à la Bourdieu.¹⁸ Instead, I show how panelists create a sense of justice, an undertaking that I argue is not only a compromise between conflicting norms, but also an outcome of following customary rules within specific constraints.¹⁹ Thus I identify a number of pragmatic constraints and customary rules that emerge from the requirements of the evaluative process: a need to finish the job within a certain time while maintaining the evaluators' commitment to the justice of the enterprise (as well as outsiders' view of the process as fair). These rules act as constraints on and regulators of behavior, but also function as justifications that create commitments in the justice of the enterprise.²⁰

Implications for Other Types of Evaluation

The implications of my analysis of peer review may be helpful for understanding evaluation across a range of contexts, such as peer review journals, university presses, tenure review committees, or college admission, as well as athletic, artistic, and financial fields.²¹ It could also enrich a much broader discussion of the group processes involved in producing legitimacy and conferring elite status in many

different kinds of organizations. Screening and ranking play a role in selecting members of elite professional organizations and hiring and promotion decisions in high-prestige occupations. In each case, actors have to reach a consensus between competing definitions or instantiations of excellence. Like peer review panels, these contexts often are characterized by strong tensions, especially those between evaluation and self-interest, and between democratic principles and expertise.

The next step is to produce a general theory of valuation and the pragmatics of evaluation, with a focus on the constraints on the actions and success of evaluators across domains of activity and institutions.²² We need a deeper understanding of the rules that evaluators follow to accomplish what they set out to do—especially rules concerning the intersubjective conventions and criteria of evaluation that escape individual control, and that are important to legitimating particular cultural products.²³ And we need to consider the increasingly complicated apparatus that produces the applicants—from the world of prep schools to graduate schools and beyond.²⁴

Belief in the legitimacy of the system is essential to preserving the vitality of research and of higher education in the United States and beyond. At the same time, a Pollyannaish support for this system, as opposed to a full recognition of its contradictory character, will ultimately weaken it. So it is crucial to recognize its necessary embeddedness in human action and its frequent conflation of judgments of quality with judgments of taste. In the end, having a better understanding of peer evaluation and its imperfections may help academics to attempt to practice it with greater self-awareness as well as increased conviction.

